

KEY BATTLE

THE BATTLE
OF RED CLIFFS
208CE

The Battle of the Red Cliffs marked the culmination of the struggle between the northern Chinese warlord Cao Cao and his southern rival Sun Quan. Although Cao Cao lost, his fleet destroyed by fire, he escaped and continued to rule the northern kingdom of Wei.



▲ The warlord Cao Cao arrives by barge on the eve of the Battle of the Red Cliffs.

KEY DEVELOPMENT

ASIAN TRADITIONS

Asian societies, in particular India and China, had their own distinctive military traditions. From the 6th century BCE onwards, large states began to appear in these areas that were able to deploy massive armies. In both China and India, however, these armies struggled to subdue nomads from Central Asia.

From the earliest times, China was the backdrop to fierce disputes between warring factions. The royal workshops of the Shang, the first historic Chinese Dynasty (1766–1122BCE), produced bronze dagger-axes, arrowheads, helmets, and shields, and early chronicles record battles against an enemy from the north called the “Tufang”, with forces that numbered up to 5,000. Army sizes increased under the succeeding Western Zhou dynasty, but it was not until a period of political fragmentation known as the Spring and Autumn period (776–403BCE) that more organized military activity began.

Spring and Autumn armies combined chariots, ridden by noble warriors armed with bows, with infantry who fought with lances. This era gave way to the Warring States period (403–221BCE), a time of incessant warfare between rival powers such as Zhao, Qi, and Qin. As armies of up to 100,000 men fought in the battles between rulers, a shift occurred in favour of infantry-based armies, while traditional weapons such as the lance (*mao*) and dagger-axe (*ge*) became longer, making them more effective when used by large numbers of troops.

The crossbow appeared, adding range to the armies’ destructive power, while military organization also became more sophisticated, with the publication of the first work on military strategy, by Sunzi, in around 500BCE. After China became united under the Qin in 221BCE, its successor dynasty, the Han, was able to call on even greater military resources, with a war tax and a pool of recruits of up to a million enabling campaigns deep into Central Asia and as far afield as Vietnam (in 111BCE).

1500–1000BCE) had a similar aristocratic tradition to that of China, in which chariot-mounted nobles armed with bows were the most important military force. By the time of the era described in the epic poems, such as the Mahabharata (around 900BCE), warfare had become more varied, with larger numbers of infantry and the first appearance of swords. As early states coalesced after 600BCE, more realistic historical records begin to emerge, recounting, for example, the wars of Bimbisara and Ajatashastru of Maghada: in their struggle against the Vriji confederacy they are said to



▲ ELEPHANTS AT WAR

War elephants are first mentioned in the Mahabharata around 1000BCE, and their use was subsequently adopted by Alexander the Great. Many other armies, such as Hannibal’s Carthaginians, also employed them.

STRUGGLES IN INDIA

The earliest archaeological indications of warfare in India come from the Indus Valley civilization, where arrowheads and flat axes have been found in the ruined city of Mohenjo-Daro, dating towards the end of the 3rd millennium BCE. The India depicted in the Vedic poems (around